Himaayah Schools
TEENAGERS BUILDING CIRCLE

FREE GUIDE

وَالْعَصْرِ * إِنَّ الْإِنسَانَ لَفِي خُسْرٍ

"By time, indeed mankind is in loss." (al-ʿAṣr 103:1–2)

Own Your Phone

A guide for Muslim teenagers on phones, screens and social media: take back your time, your focus and your peace.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Your phone can help you memorise the Qur'an, learn a skill, stay close to your family and study for your exams. It can also eat hours of your day, break your focus, disturb your sleep and show you things you wish you had never seen. The phone itself is neither good nor bad. What matters is **who is in control: you, or the phone**.

This guide is for Muslim teenagers who want to use their phones with purpose. It explains how apps are designed to hold your attention, helps you check your own habits, and gives you practical steps to take back control, with a 7-day reset, a tracker and a section for parents.

> نِعْمَتَانِ مَغْبُونٌ فِيهِمَا كَثِيرٌ مِنَ النَّاسِ: الصِّحَّةُ وَالْفَرَاغُ
>
> **"There are two blessings which many people waste: health and free time."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (6412).

The Prophet ﷺ also told us that on the Day of Judgement, a person's feet will not move until he is asked about his life and how he spent it, his youth and how he used it, his wealth, and his knowledge (at-Tirmidhī, 2417). Your teenage years are part of that youth.

Contents

01 **How your phone hooks you**
The design behind the scroll

02 **How hooked am I?**
A ten-question self-check

03 **Ten habits to take back control**
Practical steps that work

04 **Adab online**
Islamic manners for the digital world

05 **Staying safe**
Protecting yourself and others

06 **The 7-day reset and 4-week tracker**

07 **For parents**
Helping without fighting

Part 1 How your phone hooks you

Many of the most popular apps earn money from **your attention**: the more time you spend, the more adverts they can show you. So they are carefully designed to keep you using them. Knowing the tricks is the first step to beating them.

Design trick	What it does to you
Endless scroll and autoplay	There is no natural place to stop. One more video becomes fifty.
Notifications	Each buzz pulls your attention away, even when you do not check it.
Likes, views and streaks	They make you come back to check, and to feel you must keep posting.
Unpredictable rewards	You never know when something interesting will appear, so you keep refreshing, like a gambling machine.
Recommendations	The app learns what keeps you watching and feeds you more of it, including things that make you angry, envious or anxious.

What too much screen time can cost you

- **Focus.** Constant switching makes deep study harder. One study found that simply having your phone on the desk, even switched off, reduced students' available mental capacity (Ward and others, 2017).

- **Sleep.** Using the phone in bed delays sleep and makes it lighter. Teenagers need about 8 to 10 hours of sleep a night (American Academy of Sleep Medicine, 2016).
- **Mood.** Comparing your real life with other people's edited highlights can leave you feeling you are not enough.
- **Prayer and Qur'an.** Prayers get delayed "until this video ends", and the time for Qur'an disappears.
- **Modesty and heart.** Unwanted images and music, and wasted hours, harden the heart and weaken the will.

> قُل لِّلْمُؤْمِنِينَ يَغُضُّوا مِنْ أَبْصَارِهِمْ وَيَحْفَظُوا فُرُوجَهُمْ ۚ ذَٰلِكَ أَزْكَىٰ لَهُمْ
>
> **"Tell the believing men to lower their gaze and guard their private parts. That is purer for them."**
>
> An-Nūr 24:30, followed by the same command to believing women (24:31).

Part 2 How hooked am I?

Answer honestly. Give yourself **1 point** for each "yes".

No.	Question	Yes / No
1	Is your phone the first thing you check when you wake up?	
2	Do you use your phone in bed after you mean to sleep?	
3	Do you check your phone during meals or conversations?	
4	Have you delayed a prayer because you were on your phone?	
5	Do you pick up your phone without a reason, out of habit?	
6	Do you feel anxious or bored when your phone is not with you?	
7	Do you spend more than three hours a day on your phone outside schoolwork?	
8	Have your grades or revision suffered because of your phone?	
9	Do you hide what you watch from your parents?	
10	Have you tried to cut down and failed?	

Score	What it means
0–2	You are mostly in control. Keep your good habits.
3–5	Your phone is starting to control you. Pick three habits from Part 3 and start this week.
6–10	Your phone is in charge. Do the 7-day reset in Part 6, and talk to a parent or teacher you trust.

Find your real numbers

Your phone measures your screen time for you. On Android, open **Settings → Digital Wellbeing**; on iPhone, **Settings → Screen Time**. Look at your daily average and your top three apps. Most people are surprised.

Part 3 Ten habits to take back control

1. **Turn off notifications** for everything except calls and messages from real people. You decide when to check, not the app.
2. **No phone in the bedroom at night.** Charge it in another room, and use a cheap alarm clock. This one habit protects your sleep and your Fajr.
3. **Phone-free prayer.** Put the phone away before wuḍūʾ, and do not pick it up until you have finished your adhkār.
4. **Study with the phone in another room.** Not face down on the desk: in another room. Use a timer for 25–45 minute study blocks.
5. **Set app limits.** Use the timers in Digital Wellbeing or Screen Time, for example 30 minutes a day for social media.
6. **Move the time-wasters.** Take the most addictive apps off your home screen, or delete them and use them only on a computer.
7. **Try grayscale.** A black-and-white screen is much less attractive. Turn it on in your accessibility settings.
8. **Phone-free times and places**: meals, the masjid, the first hour after waking, and family time.
9. **Replace, don't just remove.** Plan what you will do instead: read, exercise, learn a skill, help at home, visit a friend.
10. **Make your phone work for you.** Keep a Qur'an app, a ḥadīth app and learning apps on your home screen, and use them first.

Rule of thumb

Before you unlock your phone, ask: **"What am I opening it for?"** If you cannot answer in one sentence, put it down.

Part 4 Adab online

The same Islamic manners apply online as offline. Every word you type is recorded, by your angels before any app: "Man does not utter any word except that with him is an observer prepared [to record]" (Qāf 50:18).

Adab	Evidence
Speak good or stay silent	"Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him speak good or remain silent" (al-Bukhārī 6018, Muslim 47).
Check before you share	"O you who believe, if a wrongdoer brings you news, verify it" (al-Ḥujurāt 49:6). "It is enough of a lie for a person to pass on everything he hears" (Muslim, 5).
No mocking, insults or nicknames	"Let not a people ridicule another people… nor insult one another with nicknames" (al-Ḥujurāt 49:11).
No backbiting	Commenting on someone behind their back, or in a group chat they are not in, is backbiting (al-Ḥujurāt 49:12).
Leave what does not concern you	"Part of the excellence of a person's Islām is leaving what does not concern him" (at-Tirmidhī, 2317).
Lower your gaze	Do not seek out what is ḥarām to look at, and look away when it appears (an-Nūr 24:30–31).
Keep private things private	Do not post other people's photos or secrets without permission. Guard your family's privacy as you would your own.

Part 5 Staying safe

- **Never share** your password, home address, school, location or phone number publicly. Turn off location sharing in apps that do not need it.
- **Strangers online are strangers.** People can pretend to be anyone. Never send photos of yourself to someone you have not met, and never arrange to meet someone from the internet without your parents.
- **If anyone asks for private photos, money or secrets, or threatens you**, stop replying, do not delete the messages, take screenshots, block and report them, and tell a parent or trusted adult at once. It is never your fault, and you will not be in trouble for telling.
- **Scams.** Offers of free data, prizes or easy money are almost always tricks. Online fraud is a crime and, for a Muslim, ḥarām: never take part in it, even as a "joke".

- **Cyberbullying.** Do not reply in anger. Save the evidence, block, report and tell an adult. If you see someone else being bullied, support them privately and report it.
- **Your digital footprint lasts.** Universities and employers may look you up. Before posting, ask: would I be happy for my parents, my teacher and my future employer to see this?

If you have already fallen into something you regret

Allah's mercy is greater than any mistake. Stop, make sincere tawbah, delete what needs to be deleted, block the sources, and talk to someone you trust. "Say: O My servants who have transgressed against themselves, do not despair of the mercy of Allah. Indeed, Allah forgives all sins" (az-Zumar 39:53).

Part 6 The 7-day reset

Day	Challenge
1	Check your screen time numbers and write them down. Turn off all non-essential notifications.
2	Charge your phone outside your bedroom tonight.
3	No phone for the first hour after waking. Pray Fajr and read some Qur'an first.
4	Move or delete your two most time-wasting apps.
5	Study for two hours with the phone in another room.
6	Phone-free day with family: meals, conversation, a walk, a visit.
7	Check your screen time again and compare with Day 1. Choose the habits you will keep.

4-week tracker

Tick each day you keep the habit.

Habit	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Phone out of bedroom at night	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐
No phone before Fajr and adhkār	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐
Notifications off	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐
Social media under my limit	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐
Studied without my phone	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	☐☐☐☐☐☐☐

Parents For parents

Rules alone rarely work with teenagers; trust, example and conversation work better. Here is what helps:

1. **Be the example.** Children copy what we do. Keep your own phone away at meals, in the masjid and during family time.
2. **Make a family media plan together**: when phones are used, where they are charged at night, which apps are allowed. Write it down and sign it together.
3. **Devices out of bedrooms at night**, for everyone in the house, parents included.
4. **Delay social media.** Most platforms require users to be at least 13. There is no rush.
5. **Use parental controls wisely**, such as Google Family Link or Apple's Screen Time, especially for younger teens, but explain why, and loosen them as trust grows.
6. **Talk, don't only ban.** Ask what they watch and who they follow. Make it safe for them to tell you when something goes wrong, without fear of losing their phone forever.
7. **Fill the time.** A teenager with nothing to do will scroll. Sport, the masjid, skills, responsibilities at home and good friends are the best protection.

Test Quick check

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **According to the ḥadīth, which two blessings do many people waste?**
   a) Wealth and children b) Health and free time c) Knowledge and youth d) Food and sleep
2. **Which verse tells us to verify news before passing it on?**
   a) Al-Ḥujurāt 49:6 b) Al-Baqarah 2:255 c) Al-Ikhlāṣ 112:1 d) Al-Kawthar 108:1
3. **What is the best place to keep your phone while studying?**
   a) Face down on the desk b) In your pocket on silent c) In another room d) In your hand
4. **Someone online asks you for private photos. What should you do?**
   a) Send them if they seem nice b) Stop replying, save the evidence, block, report and tell an adult c) Delete everything and say nothing d) Argue with them
5. **Where can an Android user see their screen time?**
   a) Settings → Digital Wellbeing b) The camera app c) The calculator d) Settings → Wallpaper

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Health and free time	4	b) Stop, save, block, report, tell
2	a) Al-Ḥujurāt 49:6	5	a) Digital Wellbeing
3	c) In another room		

References

- *The Noble Qur'an*; *Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī* 6018, 6412; *Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim* 5, 47; *Jāmiʿ at-Tirmidhī* 2317, 2417.
- Ward, A. F., Duke, K., Gneezy, A., & Bos, M. W. (2017). Brain drain: The mere presence of one's own smartphone reduces available cognitive capacity. *Journal of the Association for Consumer Research*, 2(2), 140–154.
- Paruthi, S., et al. (2016). Recommended amount of sleep for pediatric populations. *Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine*, 12(6), 785–786.
- American Academy of Pediatrics, Family Media Plan (healthychildren.org).

Join the Teenagers Building Circle

Ages 13 to 19 · four live sessions a week: deen, education, skills and personal development, with a dedicated facilitator.

Learn more: himaayahschools.com/teenagers-building-circle

General line (WhatsApp): +234 704 722 6487

وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

This guide is free to print and share. © Himaayah Schools, 2026.

Your phone is a tool, not your master.

This free guide from the Himaayah Teenagers Building Circle helps teens use their phones with purpose, protect their deen and their minds, and stay safe online.

- How apps are designed to keep you scrolling
- A self-check: how hooked am I?
- Ten habits that put you back in control
- Adab and safety online
- A 7-day reset, a 4-week tracker, and a section for parents

Join the Teenagers Building Circle

Deen, education, skills and personal development, live four times a week for ages 13 to 19.

himaayahschools.com/teenagers-building-circle